

Power ZONE

From the streets to Parliament, women in India have been trying to restructure the balance of power between the two sexes



Abolition of Dowry Act, 1961, sought to give women an equal space in society. Then in 1974 a 16-year-old girl, Mathura, in the Chandrapur district of Maharashtra was gang-raped at the local police station. The Supreme Court acquitted the policemen, stating that the victim hadn't raised an alarm and there were no injury marks suggesting consent. Protests by women groups led to an amendment in the law in 1983 that stated that if the victim said she hadn't consented, the court would presume that rape had occurred.

Women challenged societal norms too. "Thousands of women in Delhi marched together in protest against dowry. That's when the slogan, *Phool nahin chingari hain, hum Bharat ki naari hain*, became popular. The law changed right after," says activist and director of Centre for Social Research Ranjana Kumari. In 1987, a shocked nation was exposed to an archaic society in regression when in Deorala village of Rajasthan, 18-year-old Roop Kanwar was burnt on her husband's pyre.

"They must decide on abortions and about the pill, for even in sex a woman has no independence."

■ By Chitra Subramanyam

Gloria Steinem, a feminist, said, "A woman needs a man like a fish needs a bicycle." But in India, feminism is not about the war of the sexes. It is about restructuring social space to create a power balance between men and women.

Post-Independence, the Constitution became the first document that in spirit, brought men and women on the same footing. But it was in 1975, with the release of a report titled *Status of Women in India*, that the feminist movement gained momentum. One of the biggest changes began with the judiciary. Laws like the Special Marriage Act of 1954, the Hindu Marriage Act, 1955 and the

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But the feminist movement hasn't remained static. "It has moved from the politics of protest to the politics of influence," says Kumari. A case in point is the Women's Reservation Bill where women's groups have moved out of the streets and into Parliament, working at influencing the system.

The fight for equality and rights has swept through society, covering the entire spectrum from a woman's space not just at the workplace or at home but in her society and in her politics. And her voice is being heard strong, loud and clear. ■